IN A HAPPY STATE

Though economic uncertainty and civic issues still weigh on people's minds, 70 per cent of MOTN respondents—up from 51 per cent in August 2022—say they are happy

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IT could be that the past few months have been free of Covid-19 waves and major protests, or that the wounds from the carnage of the Delta variant, the farmers' protests and the unrest over the Citizenship (Amendment) Act have been healed by the passage of time, but more people are happier today than they were in August 2022, going by the findings of the latest Mood of the Nation (MOTN) survey. As many as 70 per cent of the respondents say they are very happy or somewhat happy today, compared with 51 per cent a few months ago.

Almost half the respondents say they feel free to express their opinion on religion and politics. There has been a slight decline in the percentage of those who believe that Indian democracy is in danger, from nearly 48 per cent in August 2022 to 43 per cent in the current findings. Nearly 34 per cent of the respondents remain convinced that it is the judiciary that has upheld democratic norms in the country.

Last year, data showed that state governments have announced more than Rs 1 lakh crore in social welfare schemes. From wi-fi connections to laptops and food, government handouts have been a source of succour across the country. Both the Supreme Court and the central government have cautioned against rising subsidy burdens, but MOTN findings show that a majority (49 per cent) of the respondents are happy with freebies and, in fact, prefer to receive more of them. There is also overwhelming support for reviving the old pension scheme for government employees. The question of whether such 'freebies' are in fact prudent for the government does not seem to have affected